2026 AI & Workflow Automation Checklist

For B2B founders deciding what to automate first. Tick each box as you go. Most teams find their first win in section 1.

1. Find the work worth automating

- [ ] List the 10 tasks your team repeats every week.
- [ ] Note how long each one takes and how often it happens.
- [ ] Mark the tasks that follow clear rules: same inputs, same steps, same outputs.
- [ ] Flag tasks where a mistake is expensive. Automate these with a human check first.

2. Check your data and tools

- [ ] Write down every tool involved: CRM, email, forms, spreadsheets, WhatsApp.
- [ ] Confirm each tool has an API, webhook or export you can use.
- [ ] Decide where the single source of truth lives for leads, customers and orders.
- [ ] Clean up duplicates and inconsistent fields before connecting anything.

3. Start small

- [ ] Pick one workflow with a clear start, end and owner.
- [ ] Define success with one number: hours saved, response time or error rate.
- [ ] Keep a human review step until you trust the output.
- [ ] Plan for failure: who gets alerted, and what happens in the meantime.

4. Use AI where it fits

- [ ] Use AI for reading, sorting, summarising and drafting. Use plain rules for exact calculations.
- [ ] Test with 20 to 50 real examples before going live.
- [ ] Decide what the AI should never do on its own, such as refunds, contracts or sensitive replies.
- [ ] Check privacy: what customer data leaves your systems, and where is it stored?

5. Launch and improve

- [ ] Train the people who will use it and write a one-page guide.
- [ ] Review results after two weeks and again after 30 days.
- [ ] Keep a list of exceptions and fix the most common ones first.
- [ ] Set aside time each month for maintenance and updates.